

“Ears are an erogenous zone,” Chicago-based poet Noa Micaela Fields slyly declared during a performance for the reading series Transvengence at Podlase Club in early December. A dance track produced by DJs Girly*** and Relaxxx thudded in the background while Fields read and danced. The track sampled a recording of 20th-century poet Louis Zukofsky reading from his eight hundred-plus-page life poem “A” that Fields discovered on PennSound, an online archive of downloadable recordings of poets.

A few weeks before, Fields invited a small group of her friends, myself included, to witness an early version of her multimedia performance during an intimate gathering at her apartment. I laughed when she read aloud one of my favorite poems from *E*, her forthcoming collection of homophonic translations or “mishearings” of Zukofsky’s “A”, which will be published by Nightboat Books this January. Fields gyrated her hips while reading “[Enable Dream Captions],” leaning toward her small audience as she whispered, as if revealing a detail that might embarrass the subject of her poem: “Louise Zukofsky was a technobottom. I saw her at the rave last weekend right up front by the dj, rubbing against the subwoofer. Boom boom! She leaned in to say something, I couldn’t quite catch the words but I followed the lip action, entranced.”

Louise Zukofsky is a fiction, the sissied alter ego of Louis Zukofsky invented by Fields for her debut book. Her invention recalls Robert Glück’s playful reinterpretation of 15th-century mystic Margery Kempe in his eponymous novel recounting the story of Glück’s affair with an unavailable lover named L.—a novel Fields recommended early in our friendship. Glück and his lifelong friend and collaborator Bruce Boone are widely known for starting New Narrative, a literary tradition associated with 1970s San Francisco from which Fields draws inspiration.

Often characterized by a penchant for gossip and a formal metatextual technique that allows an author to comment upon and question a story from the present, Fields references this tradition with a similar sort of mischievous, willful disregard for convention, frequently eschewing recognizable narrative or representation. Instead, mishearing is a ritual practice of meaning-making that allows Fields to “erect countless horizons of meaning.” As she writes in “Exquisite Corpus:” “Pivoting, E calls— / wants to mother. Bottomless the exploits / that created woman of man- / y possibilities,” a tongue-in-cheek allusion to her hormonal transition used as fodder for this distorted sequel to Zukofsky’s disjunctive “A” while the titular vowel itself (a wry stand-in for both estrogen and ecstasy) becomes a character luring Fields toward the possibility of herself.

After the performance, a small group of us lingered on the leather sofas in Podlase, where Fields ecstatically reached for our mutual friend’s copy of Derrida’s *On Touching—Jean-Luc Nancy*. Fields praised the book and recalled conversations with one of their former lovers about deconstructionism, their shared affection for the Spanish phrase “pero también” (but also) because of its additive, often contradictory grammatical function. Like an interloper, *E* embodies the spirit of this correlative conjunction, flirtatiously inserting queerness into a monument of American poetry.